Argumentative Writing

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Argumentative Writing

- Involves organizing and presenting our well-reasoned conclusions in order to persuade the readers to accept—or at least seriously consider—our point of view
- Arguments are claims backed by reasons that are supported by evidence.
- Objective: to present our view, to argue and persuade
- Includes description and analysis to support our perspective
- Requires evaluation of the support for our claims
- Each claim needs supporting evidence; primary or secondary
- Argue either for (pro) or against (con) the statement

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Argumentative Essay

Individualism is a fundamental part of society in many countries. Most people believe in the right to express their own opinion without fear of punishment. This value, however, is coming under fire in an unlikely place-the public-school classroom. The issue is school uniforms. Should public school students be allowed to make individual decisions about clothing, or should all students be required to wear a uniform? School uniforms are the better choice for three reasons.

First, wearing school uniforms would help make students' lives simpler. They would no longer have to decide what to wear every morning, sometimes trying on outfit after outfit in an effort to choose. Uniforms would not only save time but also would eliminate the stress often associated with this chore.

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Second, school uniforms influence students to act responsibly in groups and as individuals. Uniforms give students the message that school is a special place for learning. In addition, uniforms create a feeling of unity among students. For example, when students do something as a group, such as attend meetings in the auditorium or eat lunch in the cafeteria, the fact that they all wear the same uniform gives them a sense of community. Even more important, statistics show the positive effects that school uniforms have on violence and truancy. According to a recent survey in a large school district in Florida, incidents of school violence dropped by 50 percent, attendance and test scores improved, and student suspensions declined approximately 30 percent after school uniforms were introduced.

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Finally, school uniforms would help make all the students feel equal. Students' standards of living differ greatly from family to family, and some people are well-off while others are not. People sometimes forget that school is a place to get an education, not to promote a "fashion show'. Implementing mandatory school uniforms would make all the students look the same regardless of their financial status. School uniforms would promote pride and help to raise the self-esteem of students who cannot afford to wear expensive clothing.

Opponents of mandatory uniforms say that students who wear school uniforms cannot express their individuality. This point has some merit on the surface. **However, as stated previously, school is a place to learn, not to flaunt wealth and fashion.** Society must decide if individual expression through clothing is more valuable than improved educational performance. It is important to remember that school uniforms would be worn only during school hours. Students can express their individuality in the way that they dress outside of the classroom.

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In conclusion, there are many well-documented benefits of implementing mandatory school uniforms for students. Studies show that students learn better and act more responsibly when they wear uniforms. Public schools should require uniforms in order to benefit both the students and society as a whole.

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Three techniques of critical argumentation

Counter-argument: It is the opposing point of view. By including the counter-argument, the writer shows an awareness of opposite views on the topic.

Opponents of mandatory uniforms say that students who wear school uniforms cannot express their individuality.

Concession: In a concession the writer agrees that the opposing point of view has some strength.

Opponents of mandatory uniforms say that students who wear school uniforms cannot express their individuality. This point has some merit on the surface.

Refutation: It is the writer's response to the counter-argument. In the refutation, the writer shows why the counter-argument is weak and his or her position is strong.

This point has some merit on the surface. However, as stated previously, school is a place to learn, not to flaunt wealth and fashion.

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Identify the supporting statements (From Cambridge Academic English)

Natural disasters have a greater impact on less economically developed countries (LEDCs) than more economically developed countries (MEDCs).

1. Healthcare facilities in LEDCs are often less able to cope with demand after a natural disaster.
2. Factors other than the level of national development influence how severe the impact of a natural disaster on a country is.
3. Disasters have a greater economic impact on poorer people than better-off people..
4. Infrastructure (e.g. roads, airports, electricity and gas supply) in LEDCs is often of poorer quality, and can easily be damaged or destroyed in natural disasters.
5. While MEDCs may be better placed than LEDCs to face natural disasters, there may be variation within MEDCs.
6. In some LEDCs there are only basic water and sewage facilities, which can easily be damaged by natural disasters.
7. Most people who die as a result of natural disasters are in LEDCs.
8. Tourism, which is an important part of the economy in many LEDCs, can be particularly badly hit by damage to infrastructure.
9. MECDs have more developed infrastructure, which is very expensive to replace or repair if it is damaged.
10. Fewer people in LEDCs have insurance against property damage

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Identify the supporting statements (From Cambridge Academic English)

Natural disasters have a greater impact on less economically developed countries (LEDCs) than more economically developed countries (MEDCs).

1. Healthcare facilities in LEDCs are often less able to cope with demand after a natural disaster. **Y**
2. Factors other than the level of national development influence how severe the impact of a natural disaster on a country is. **N**
3. Disasters have a greater economic impact on poorer people than better-off people. **Y?**
4. Infrastructure (e.g. roads, airports, electricity and gas supply) in LEDCs is often of poorer quality, and can easily be damaged or destroyed in natural disasters. **Y**
5. While MEDCs may be better placed than LEDCs to face natural disasters, there may be variation within MEDCs. **N**
6. In some LEDCs there are only basic water and sewage facilities, which can easily be damaged by natural disasters. **Y**
7. Most people who die as a result of natural disasters are in LEDCs. **Y**
8. Tourism, which is an important part of the economy in many LEDCs, can be particularly badly hit by damage to infrastructure. **Y**
9. MECDs have more developed infrastructure, which is very expensive to replace or repair if it is damaged. **N**
10. Fewer people in LEDCs have insurance against property damage. **Y**

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Can you categorize us?

Natural disasters have a greater impact on less economically developed countries (LEDCs) than more economically developed countries (MEDCs).

1. Healthcare facilities in LEDCs are often less able to cope with demand after a natural disaster.
2. Disasters have a greater economic impact on poorer people than better-off people.
3. Infrastructure (e.g. roads, airports, electricity and gas supply) in LEDCs is often of poorer quality, and can easily be damaged or destroyed in natural disasters.
4. In some LEDCs there are only basic water and sewage facilities, which can easily be damaged by natural disasters.
5. Most people who die as a result of natural disasters are in LEDCs.
6. Tourism, which is an important part of the economy in many LEDCs, can be particularly badly hit by damage to infrastructure.
7. Fewer people in LEDCs have insurance against property damage.

Number of lives lost:

Economic impact:

Health impact:

Number of lives lost: 5

Economic impact: 2, 3, 6, 7

Health impact: 1, 4

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Five types of evidence or support

1. Quotation
2. Example
3. Statistics
4. Research findings
5. Personal experience

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Match us: 1d, 2c, 3e, 4b, 5a

a) Quotation **b) Example** **c) Statistics** **d) Research findings** **e) Personal experience**

1 Research has shown that the United States and Japan suffered the most economic damage from natural disasters between 1991 and 2005 (Wills, 2009).

2 Between 1991 and 2005, 630,000 people were killed by natural disasters in LEDCs compared with 72,000 in MEDCs (International Strategy for Disaster Reduction, 2010).

3 When I did voluntary work in Haiti after the 2010 earthquake, the medical services there were clearly unable to deal with the huge number injured.

4 For example, most of the farming population of Bangladesh live in low-lying parts of the country where severe floods occur regularly.

5 "Although a household on a lower income may spend less in total terms than a wealthier household, they are likely to spend a higher proportion of their income on recovery" (Adams, 2008).

(From Cambridge Academic English)

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Match us: 1c, 2a, 3d, 4e, 5b

Support	Claim
1 Research has shown that the United States and Japan suffered the most economic damage from natural disasters between 1991 and 2005 (Wills, 2009).	a Most people who die as a result of natural disasters are in LEDCs.
2 Between 1991 and 2005, 630,000 people were killed by natural disasters in LEDCs compared with 72,000 in MEDCs (International Strategy for Disaster Reduction, 2010).	b Disasters have a greater economic impact on poorer people than better-off people.
3 When I did voluntary work in Haiti after the 2010 earthquake, the medical services there were clearly unable to deal with the huge number injured.	c MEDCs have more developed infrastructure, which is very expensive to replace or repair if it is damaged.
4 For example, most of the farming population of Bangladesh live in low-lying parts of the country where severe floods occur regularly.	d Healthcare facilities in LEDCs are often less able to cope with demand after a natural disaster.
5 "Although a household on a lower income may spend less in total terms than a wealthier household, they are likely to spend a higher proportion of their income on recovery" (Adams, 2008).	e Poorer people may have to risk living in disaster-prone areas in order to make a living.

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Argumentative Essay plan

Topic: Mandatory physical education in school

TS: Physical education should be required for all public-school students in all grades.

Introduction (paragraph 1):

Hook: Question/interesting statistic/anecdote/quotation

Background: Linking hook with thesis to provide background information

Thesis Statement:

Body (paragraph 2): Pro argument 1

Topic sentence: Physical education courses promote children's general health

Support 1: Researchers have proved that exercise has maximum benefit if done regularly.

Support 2: Students should learn the importance of physical fitness at an early age.

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Argumentative Essay plan

Body (paragraph 3): Pro argument 2

Topic sentence: Physical education teaches children transferable life skills

Support 1: Kids learn about teamwork while playing team sports.

Support 2: Kids learn about the benefits of healthy competition.

Body (paragraph 4): (counterargument and refutation)

Counterargument: Some parents might claim that only academic subjects should be taught in school.

Refutation: Most parents do not have the time or the resources to see to it that their children are getting enough exercise.

Conclusion (paragraph 5):

Restated thesis
Summary of main ideas
Final thought

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Essay writing task

Topic: **Are social networking sites building or breaking human relationships?**

In about 400 words

Write your details on the sheet.

Prepare a mind map of the ideas.

After completion of the essay, take a pick of it.

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